

Moblin 2.1: Linux for your mobile devices

Moblin is short for 'mobile Linux'. Well, it's also a Linux-based OS (the official release is a Fedora derivative) that's optimised for small computing devices. Naturally, this calls for a complete UI overhaul—nothing like the GNOME and KDE we're used to and fight over.

The Linux Foundation released Moblin 2.1 on November 5, which made us take it for a test drive on the netbooks.

Installation

The installation procedure that worked for us:

1. Download the image file from <http://moblin.org/downloads>
2. Insert a USB drive (minimum 1GB)—make sure the drive is unmounted—and run the following command as root:

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dd bs=4096 if=/path/to/image-file of=/dev/sdX
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 ...where X in sdX is the number for your connected USB device.
3. Now, you can boot your machine off the USB drive and install Moblin just the way you would, for any other distro. Yes, it's that simple!

Faster boot... and shut down?

On the ASUS Eee PC 1008HA (as it is configured today as I write this), from the time the power button is pressed until the machine is up and ready to go is 30 seconds. BIOS consumes 8 seconds, and Moblin boot consumes an additional 22 seconds. The shut down time for the OS was 8 seconds. This runs in sharp contrast to the boot times reported by the guys at Moblin, on their internal builds, which are already in the sub-10 second boot range.

Users want much faster boot times from cold starts. This is something Intel (and Google as well) recognise, and is a major area of focus today.

Initial impressions

The team working on Moblin has not been complacent in their duty to provide us with a powerful new GUI.

plenty of attractive eye-candy and fast operating graphical features. Even so, and to address the graphical needs of a full-on Moblin experience, the team realised that more software support was needed than was possible, at least not without digging deep into the innards of Linux and seeing what's there and what needed to be changed—and that's exactly what they did.

The traditional desktop environment is replaced in Moblin. Yet, the desktop should seem to be highly GNOME based. At the top of the screen is a bar which appears either when you press the Super key, or move the mouse towards the top. It auto-hides graphically, which can sometimes be very annoying since once one gets used to the environment, having this graphical sequence of sliding down 3/4-inch, even though it takes only about half a second, is not amusing.

A completely revamped UI

Graphically, Moblin is very well designed. It's attractive, and uses the available space quite well. Everything has a good default contrast ratio, and colours appear vibrant on both icons and dialogues. It's very clear the Moblin design team wanted a powerful visual experience. Honestly though, I think the team went a little overboard with some of the GUI effects.

For example, every time the mouse is moved over one of the icons, it bounces as the tool tip text appears beneath it. This is extremely annoying to me as a consistent visual trait that appears, no matter how fast I mouse over something and click on it. I'm sure each graphical effect takes only about 1/8 second or so, but after the initial sheen is gone, the delay and bouncing graphics starts to become an eye sore. A nice feature would be the ability to turn this graphical trait off.

Alt+Tab cycles through open applications in a pleasing graphical way, with a thumbnail of each being shown. In many cases, this is the only way to get to the other applications that are running since only one



▲ MyZone—the default screen



▲ The Gecko-based Web browser